

SAHKAR SE SAMRIDDHI

NAFED'S ROLE IN CULTIVATING A NEW ERA OF COOPERATIVE SUCCESS IN INDIA

As India heralds 2025 as the International Year of Cooperatives, the spotlight shines brightly on NAFED–the National Agricultural Cooperative Marketing Federation of India Ltd.–a pivotal force in the nation's agricultural transformation since 1958. In this interview with its Chairman Shri Jethabhai Ahir, we delve deep into NAFED's historic journey, recent groundbreaking achievements, and ambitious vision for the future. Read on to explore how NAFED is reshaping Indian agriculture, driving rural empowerment, and building a cooperative ecosystem poised to uplift millions across the country.



Jethabhai Ahir
Chairman
NAFED

Q. NAFED has a storied presence in Indian agriculture since 1958. Can you briefly recount its journey and how its core mission has evolved over the decades?

A. When we started NAFED back in 1958, India was working hard to become self-sufficient in agriculture. Our founders had a clear but crucial goal: make sure farmers got fair prices for their crops and protect them from middlemen who were taking advantage of them.

It's been quite a journey since then. What began as a marketing cooperative has grown into something much bigger. Today, we're involved in practically every aspect of agriculture - from buying crops directly from farmers to processing them, managing supply chains, and adding value to agricultural products. We help farmers through our minimum support price operations, provide them with quality certified seeds, encourage organic farming, and we've even started helping them sell their produce internationally.

At its core, our mission hasn't changed - we're still here to empower farmers, make rural communities stronger, and keep India food secure. But the way we do it keeps changing with the times. We're using technology now, digital platforms, and finding new ways to do business that actually work for farmers in today's world.

It's not just about being a cooperative anymore; it's about being partners with the farmers who feed our nation.

Q. Under your leadership, what have been the most impactful achievements of NAFED, especially in recent years?

A. Several milestones come to mind. Most notably, we've streamlined direct procurement from farmers, significantly reducing the role of intermediaries and passing benefits directly to cultivators. This initiative, recently announced by the Honourable Union Minister Amit Shah, will soon make NAFED India's foremost organization for direct farmer engagement at scale. Another achievement is the expansion and modernization of our retail and distribution network through 'NAFED Bazaar' franchise outlets and mobile vans. The rollout of the Bharat Brand Products in partnership with government initiatives has brought essential commodities to consumers at reasonable prices while supporting farmers with assured procurement. As of February 2025, we had sold over 121,000 MT of these products nationwide.

NAFED is also playing a key role in India's International Year of Cooperatives 2025 celebrations, fostering farmer empowerment, promoting best agricultural practices, supporting self-help groups, and organizing capacity-building events. Our activities now extend to international trade: participating in major global exhibitions like Gulfood in Dubai and aligning with Lulu Group to bring NAFED products to international retail stores. Most importantly, we're supporting Farmer Producer Organisations (FPOs) with equity grants, technical support, and market linkages, giving rise to truly empowered cooperative business ventures across the country.

Q. NAFED's role at forums like the recent Cooperative Summit has been widely acknowledged. What were the key messages and outcomes from your participation there?

A. The recent Cooperative Summit in June 2025 in collaboration with India Today was a landmark event for the cooperative movement. It underscored the government's commitment to deepening and expanding the reach of cooperatives to every village panchayat.NAFED's role, highlighted at the summit, focused on supporting FPOs—disbursing equity grants, launching new franchisees of NAFED Bazaar, and ensuring cooperatives gain operational capacity and better market access. Our efforts, showcased at this summit, reinforce our commitment to rural prosperity through 'Sahkar se Samriddhi'—Prosperity through Cooperation.